

A comparison of popular smart LED bulbs in the market

Model	Communication technology	Requires hub?	Approximate price per kit	Approximate price per bulb	Life of bulb in years	Energy consumed at full brightness (W)	Light output (lumens)	Availability in India
Philips Hue	Zigbee	Yes	Three bulbs plus hub costs between \$180 and \$200	\$30	10	9	750	Yes
LIFX	Wi-Fi	No	—	\$99	25	18	1017	Yes
iLumi	Bluetooth classic and Bluetooth low-energy	No	—	\$90 (small) \$100 (large)	20	13 (small) 17 (large)	800+ (small) 1100+ (large)	Yes
WeMo smart LED bulbs	Zigbee	Yes	Two bulbs plus hub priced at \$100	\$30	23	10	800+	Not yet (try online)
GE Link	Zigbee	Yes	Two bulbs plus hub costs around \$50	\$15	23	12	800	Plans to launch in emerging markets like India

Each bulb comes with in-built Wi-Fi capability, so it can communicate directly with your smartphone and be controlled with the LIFX app. You can comfortably control around 50 bulbs with the app, so LIFX can be considered for ambient lighting in larger spaces, too.

Professional reviewers laud LIFX for its great hardware, but claim it is not smart enough yet, as the app has minimal features. While you can remotely control the bulb, vary the hue and brightness, and achieve all the basics comfortably, the app supposedly lacks advanced scheduling and other such features. That said, the company does seem to be updating its offering with features like

automatic brightening and dimming of light when you wake up or drift-off to sleep.

WeMo smart LED bulbs: From home-automation experts

Coming from Belkin, which has a strong background in easy-to-use home-automation products, WeMo smart LED bulbs are rich in features, as expected. The setup is very similar to the Philips system, with Zigbee-powered LED light bulbs, a WeMo Link hub that mediates between the bulbs and your Wi-Fi network, and a smartphone app.

Like the products seen earlier, the app lets you remotely control, schedule and program your bulbs. One of the interesting features of the WeMo app, which stands out from others is the 'simulated occupancy' option, which randomly switches lights, music, etc, on or off automatically, to make it appear like you are at home, when you might be away on a vacation.

Since WeMo has a broad range of home-automation products, it is possible to club your bulbs with more bulbs—WeMo switch, WeMo Motion, WeMo light switch and WeMo Insight switches. WeMo also proposes to include IFTTT in the near future.

GE: Link and Wink

One more interesting product set for launch this fall is the GE Link smart

LED bulb, which works with GE's emerging smart home platform. Like other Zigbee based light bulbs, Link requires an intermediary hub. While this sounds cumbersome, there are two things that work in its favour. One is the relatively low price of the bulb, at \$15. A kit of two bulbs and a hub would be just around \$50, which is much cheaper than other brands. The other advantage is the compatibility with Wink, a platform that is so well-accepted in the market that most popular home-automation products, including those from Quirky, Dropcam, Philips, TCP and Honeywell, work with it.

This is not an exclusive list of smart lights. There are many more smart lights, and a great choice of automation platforms, like Infinion and Connect4, that broaden the scope of smart lighting. As the market picks up, surely we will see more products coming up, and as adoption improves, prices are likely to drop, too. The technology, however, is more or less stable. So, if you want to buy an interesting New Year's gift for yourself, unmindful of the price, a smart light bulb might be a good choice! Just make sure you visit online stores to check who delivers in India and find a good price deal, too. ●



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